

‘How Can It Not Know What It Is?’: Self and Other in Ridley Scott’s *Blade Runner*

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The Myth of Lost Origins: Identity and Authenticity

Ridley Scott’s 2007 masterpiece *Blade Runner* is a science fiction film, and, like most such films, it is a fantasy about the future, a future in which scientific and technological development has profoundly altered the possibilities open to us.² But *Blade Runner* is also a film about the past.³ This is most obvious in its evocation of film noir, the mid-twentieth century genre or pseudo-genre of films associated with actors such as Humphrey Bogart and Ida Lupino and directors such as Nicholas Ray, John Huston, and Billy Wilder. Film noir, as the name announces, is film about the dark side, about morally ambiguous, isolated, cynical people—usually detectives or criminals in a world characterized by stark class divisions—shot in darkened frames that highlight the moral murkiness of the characters and their societies, and the grimness of their fates. It is not hard, even from this quick sketch, to see Scott’s dark tale as one that hearkens back to a filmic past, even as it projects that past into the future. Harrison Ford’s character, Rick Deckard, is a weary, cynical man trying, and failing, to retire from his job as a Blade Runner in the corrupt police force of a future Los Angeles—a city which has deteriorated from being a sprawling, sunlit metropolis to a stifling, towering urban inferno completely devoid of children, natural animals, and plants, where the clouds part only to show the sun setting. Within this city’s polyglot chaos, the distinction between public and private space is almost completely effaced, and interior spaces are constantly probed and violated by lights shining from the crowded streets and vehicles hovering in the darkened skies above them.⁴ The sun is setting here not just on the decaying city, but on the earth itself, the remaining healthy inhabitants of which are abandoning it for ‘Off-world’ colonies—colonies made possible by expansionist intergalactic war. And the sun is also, finally, setting on humanity itself, as least as it has been known it up to now. The development of robot slaves who fulfil their producer’s claim of being ‘more human than human’ threatens to erase the line separating the human being from its tools, and empty the concept of ‘humanity’ of what meaning it has left after the horrors of the 20th century. And the deepest sense in which this film about our future is also about the past concerns the way the

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² Although *Blade Runner* initially appeared in 1982, the definitive ‘Final Cut’ appeared in 2007. For its status, see director Ridley Scott’s introduction in the Warner Brothers’ four-disc box set of the film.

³ This point is discussed more fully in Silverman 1991, 109ff.

⁴ This is a central theme of Bukatman 1997.

film articulates the question of the fate of the human in terms of the *past* of the agent involved. Being human here, it seems, is a matter less of what you can do, than of where you came from, what you once were, where your origins lie.⁵ If the standard mode of defining or delineating the human being at least since Aristotle is to identify a *capacity* and hence a *telos* or end that is unique to human beings, the Replicants of *Blade Runner* threaten to undermine this project, and reduce to us to identifying the human in circular terms, as an agent born of human beings.⁶

The mystery of the Replicants hangs upon their memories of the past. Unlike a traditional tool, which is wielded by the human hand, or a machine, which is tended and guided by it, the Replicants have no need for intelligent (human) direction. They are themselves self-directing, *minded* agents, with physical and, in time, emotional responses of their own. These responses are coherent, in the sense that they hang together so as to express a personal identity. In contrast to the coordinated movements of, say, an ant colony, the responses of a Replicant reflect personal dispositions, each of which is a state of an enduring and developing organic whole, rather than the discrete parts of which it is made.⁷ The ability to respond as an organism to new and complicated situations sets the Replicants on the path towards the eventual development of emotions, in which situations and events *act upon them* or *move them* (emotion, *emouvoir*, to stir up) in a variety of ways, making them ‘excited,’ ‘angered,’ ‘pleased,’ ‘frightened,’ and so on. The Replicants we see in the film not only experience such affective states, but form attachments and loyalties that require coordinating and ranking their desires in a manner that both expresses and determines *who* they are.⁸ (Consider in this regard Leon’s violent rage at the killing of Zhora, his desire to avenge her by beating Deckard to death, and his remark,

⁵ This distinction comes to the fore when Rachel plays piano for Deckard in his apartment, and remarks that she remembers having lessons, but she was not sure that that meant that she could actually play, as the memories were only implants. He responds, with emphasis, ‘You play beautifully,’ as if to insist that what matters, in the end, and in the face of their assumptions up to that point, is what we do, not what we were. Human is as human does, so to speak. But this is obviously a moment of protest.

⁶ Except where otherwise indicated, I use the term ‘Replicant’ to refer to the most advanced model, the NEXUS 6.

⁷ See in this regard Williams 2002, where Bernard Williams argues that the character Rameau, in Diderot’s *Rameau’s Nephew*, lacks a character to which he might be true, his constantly changing (though sincerely expressed) views and moods more like ‘a swarm of bees’ (Williams 2002, 190). Such a person is incapable of projecting him- or herself into the future, or being true to the past: ‘the declaration at a given instant of self can only be a declaration of self at that instant’ (Williams 2002, 190). Williams sees this as a marginal mode of personhood, and argues that ‘our declarations do need to be patterned in some ways rather than others if they are to count as declarations of *any* sort of belief or opinion’ (Williams 2002, 192), as opposed to a mere impulse. This is made possible, on his account, thorough a complex set of social practices ‘that firms up the expression of the immediate state into something that has a future’ (Williams 2002, 192).

⁸ This development is thus something that the Replicants’ makers know they cannot stop. At a certain level of complexity, the shift from mechanical to organic, affective response is inevitable. Or so the film seems to assume.

while trying to do so, ‘Painful to live in fear, isn’t it?’ Neither the love of Zhora, nor the desire to avenge her, nor the fear of a coming death are possible without an identity that endures in time and is aware of itself doing so.⁹) To function as it does in the world, each Replicant must have a sense of being a temporally extended being, one whose enduring relationships and future prospects concern an identity which has already been established. Their memories of themselves thus rest at the heart of their identity. Being made rather than born and grown, they do not naturally develop extensive sets of such memories or a rich sense of themselves. Hence, at least some of the most recent models receive memory *implants*.¹⁰

The resulting identities satisfy the criteria of one of the most influential modern accounts of personal identity, that of John Locke. Locke notes that agents’ bodies change radically over time, and he concludes that personal identity cannot be based on physical continuity. Instead, it is based upon the continuity of *consciousness*:

it being the same consciousness that makes a Man be himself to himself, *personal Identity* depends on that only, [regardless of] whether it be annexed only to one individual Substance, or can be continued in a succession of several Substances. For as far as any intelligent being can repeat the *Idea* of any past Action with the same consciousness it had at first, and with the same consciousness it has of any present Action, so far is it the same *personal self*. (Locke 1991, 336)

On Locke’s account, it is not enough to have the *idea* of the past action, as many persons might have the same idea; one must be able to have it ‘with the same consciousness,’ that is, with the consciousness that the person has had this idea before.¹¹ It is this consciousness or memory that makes the idea *mine*, and that reveals who *I* am, what *identity* is mine. The Replicants’ evaluative responses are their own—and hence can be mutually coordinated

⁹ Roy Batty also seeks revenge for his comrades. And all of them come to earth in a desperate attempt to achieve ‘more life,’ a project that requires a care for the self and an ability to distinguish between that care and the attempt to satisfy a current given desire. That is to say, all act on the desire to live, but this desire is one that they *anticipate* having when their four-year lifecycle is over. Coming to earth in no way allows them ‘more life’ *now*.

¹⁰ I assume that this is what Tyrell refers to when he tells Deckard, ‘If we give them a past, we create a cushion or pillow for their emotions and consequently we can control them better.’ Affective responses will destabilize the agent in the absence of a sense of how those responses might fit together, of who it is that is being moved by the world in this way. I note in passing that there is little reason to believe Tyrell when he insists that Rachel is distinguished from other Replicants by her implanted memories. We learn that Deckard himself has implanted memories, and the ability of the other Replicants to function as they do suggests that they have a much larger store of memories, and a correspondingly much greater sense of who they are, than two or three years would allow.

¹¹ Compare Locke 1991, 96-7: ‘to remember is to perceive any thing with memory, or with a consciousness, that it was known or perceived before.’

and informed—because their identities cohere and endure over time. But, because their memories are implanted, they and the identities these memories make possible are in a sense *not* their own. When Rachel learns she is a Replicant, she learns that the memories she has of her mother and her childhood are those of Tyrell's niece—a fact she finds utterly heartbreaking. But these memories are, in another sense, nonetheless her own. Learning that the memories have been implanted does not make them go away, and it does not make it possible for her to arbitrarily replace them with other memories. Nor does it reveal her to 'really' be Tyrell's niece. 'Her' past endures, in a mythic form, and it continues to ground her independent identity. That identity, however, is revealed to be hers in an ambiguous manner: it is, one might say, inauthentic.

Replicants are thus understood best not so much as false persons, but as *inauthentic* persons—as Heidegger puts it, *uneigentlich* or *improper* persons who as such nonetheless lack that which is most proper to personhood, or who possess it in a way that they have yet to make their own (*eigen*). In contrast to the cyborg killer played by Arnold Schwarzenegger in the roughly contemporaneous film, *Terminator*, Replicants are not machines disguised in a suit of living flesh which they can discard when necessary. The disguise, such that it is, is a feature of their own experience, and not just the experience of those around them. This is symbolized in the fact that the test used to identify Replicants, the Voigt-Kampff Empathy Test, entails looking into *their* eyes, and seeing what is unconsciously expressed in the organ through which *they* see the world. (In *Terminator*, the cyborg's eye also plays an important role; but in that film the audience does actually get to see what the cyborg sees, and, in seeing that, the audience sees that the terminator is indeed not one of us, but a computerized machine. Nothing like this occurs in *Blade Runner*.) The Cartesian echoes of *Blade Runner* are often commented upon. (Pris actually quotes the most famous sentence in Descartes when speaking with J.F. Sebastian: 'I think, . . . therefore I am.') Just as Descartes in the *Meditations* imagines that all of his 'experiences' of the world might be false because they might be the product of an all-powerful Evil Demon intent on deceiving him, so the similarly named Deckard learns that what appeared to be his own memories have in fact been implanted by the Tyrell Corporation.¹² But there is a crucial difference: for Descartes, what is at stake is the ability of his experiences to successfully and accurately refer to an external reality. As he puts it, when he imagines the Evil Demon as the vehicle of the scepticism

¹² While some have thought that Deckard's status as a Replicant is ambivalent, I would argue that the origami of a unicorn (itself a composite or artificial organic being) that Gaff leaves for Deckard and Deckard's look of recognition of the signal this sends that his waking vision of the unicorn charging through the misty forest is an implant effectively ends any debate on the matter. This is not to say, of course, that it is unimportant for the initial experience of the film that one slowly learns, along with Deckard, what kind of being he is.

he wishes to conclusively defeat, he imagines that ‘the heavens, the air, the earth, colours, shapes, sounds and all external things that we see, are only illusions and deceptions [the demon] uses to take me in’ (Descartes 1968, 100).¹³ But what is at stake in *Blade Runner* is not the veridical status or accuracy of the memory—Did my mother actually do that?—or the veridical status of what is remembered—Did the mother I seemed to see actually exist?—but the ability of the agent to stand in the proper relationship to her memories and, ultimately, her self—Was that *my* mother at all? What is lost to Descartes is the world he thought he knew; what is lost to Deckard is the (authentic) self he thought he really was.¹⁴

In the Voigt-Kampff empathy test, what is decisive is not only whether the subject has an emotional response, but whether it comes in the right time. As Leon is told in his test, ‘reaction time is a factor.’ The Replicant may well respond correctly, but she will not consistently do so quickly enough. The monster in *The Terminator* feels nothing; it is a killing machine, and nothing more. The Replicant feels, but not ‘in the human way,’ we might say. Any doubts about this are immediately shown to be unfounded when the initial interview ends with Leon shooting the interrogator in response to a question about his mother. ‘My mother? . . . Let me tell you about my mother.’ The fact of being a Replicant entails its own emotional states, among them rage at being made, and not born. None of this, however, adds up to a set of criteria that can be used to distinguish between human and non-human with much confidence or precision.¹⁵ Being born as opposed to being made is never an object of one’s own experience and knowledge, and many of us enjoy ‘memories’ of our childhoods that are mistaken, exaggerated, or wholly unfounded.¹⁶ If Replicants feel, but they do not feel ‘in the human way,’ what then *is* the human way? Is it human always to feel empathy for a sentient creature in pain, and to do so immediately? When the stoned, decadent patrons of Taffey Lewis’ Snake Pit enjoy watching a young woman whom they assume to be a human employee have sex on stage with an artificial snake, is their pleasure a human one in these terms? More generally, do any of the

¹³ This same hypothesis is at play in Putnam 1981.

¹⁴ A better parallel to Descartes would be the 1988 John Carpenter film, *They Live* (where the invading aliens trick the hapless earthlings into seeing them as fellow humans, until the hero finds a special pair of sunglasses that allow him to see them and the rest of reality as they and it really are) or, more famously, the Wachowski brothers’ 1999 film, *The Matrix*.

¹⁵ This sharply distinguishes *Blade Runner* from its perhaps most illustrious predecessor, Don Siegel’s 1956 *Invasion of the Body Snatchers*. While Siegel’s film also raises the spectre of an uncanny false humanity, it does not in the end follow through on that promise, and retains the notion of a reliable criterion that distinguishes false humans from real ones: the ability to act as a human does with *feeling*. As in Fritz Lang’s 1927 *Metropolis*, in which the machine man who takes on Maria’s appearance cannot replicate her divine character, there remains a test of the human that a non-biased observer might use with confidence.

¹⁶ It is a commonplace that the vivid imagination and love of a good story of parents and older siblings are the true source of a many a childhood ‘memory.’

human masters of the Replicants feel sufficient or sufficiently timely empathy at the fate of the sentient beings that serve them? Such questions are not easily answered by mechanically following a method or applying a set of criteria—a fact to which the film may allude in making the device used in the empathy test *breathe*. And they are not, in any event, questions that the human beings in the film (or those who appear to be human beings) have much desire to pursue. When, early on in the film, Deckard and his boss Bryant wonder what will happen if the Voigt-Kampff Empathy Test doesn't work on the NEXUS 6 Replicants, they do not entertain the possibility that a successful performance by a Replicant would show that he or she was empathetic enough to be considered a kind of human being. The test, for them, at this point, does not search for the essential property of the human being, but for a mark that contingently stands in for whatever that property might be. The assumption seems to be that if empathy does not allow for the distinction between human and Replicant, something else must be found. What the real difference between the two might be, or whether there really is one, is simply not asked.¹⁷

Empathy Tests and Other Minds

The Voigt-Kampff Empathy Test, however, plays a considerably more significant role in the film quite beyond the blatantly instrumental one implicitly assigned to it in Deckard and Bryant's conversation. In the novel upon which the film is loosely based, Philip K. Dick's 1968 *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* the test is presented as testing what kind of creature the test subject is—in particular whether it is a social creature with an affective connection with the natural world. Early on in the book, Rick reflects on the inability of the androids which he hunts, however intelligent, to empathize with others:

Empathy, evidently, existed only within the human community, whereas intelligence to some degree could be found throughout every phylum and order including the archnida. For one thing, the empathetic faculty probably required an unimpaired group instinct; a solitary organism, such as a spider, would have no use for it; in fact, it would tend to abort a spider's ability to survive. It would make him

¹⁷ Of course, the test in Rachel's case does 'work,' and indeed Rachel's downcast look at the end of it suggests that she already doubts that she has passed it. But Bryant and Deckard are plainly concerned that results of this sort will not be possible in the near future. Their attitude towards this possibility is reminiscent of American race relations: blacks were once considered inferior to whites because they were not capable of intellectual work; now that sufficient numbers of black citizens have been given the opportunity to demonstrate that they can do this work, blacks are considered inferior to whites on 'cultural' grounds. Because the distinction is felt to be necessary, the criteria for making it are always liable to alternation.

conscious of the desire to live on the part of his prey. (Dick 2007, 455)¹⁸

Rick concludes from this that empathy must be limited to herbivores or omnivores. And he speculates that the test might ultimately gauge whether the test subject felt her- or himself to be a part of the natural world as a whole:

Oddly, it [‘the empathetic gift’] resembled a sort of biological insurance, but double-edged. As long as some creature experienced joy, then the condition for all other creatures included a fragment of joy. However, if any living being suffered, then for all the rest the shadow could not be entirely cast off. (Dick 2007, 456)¹⁹

The small portions of the two tests that we see in the film generally fit this account. Deckard in the film says a standard test consists of twenty or thirty cross-referenced questions; Rachel’s test is four or five times that long. We observe seven questions all told, two from Leon’s test and five from Rachel’s. Of these, five address the subject’s feelings towards the suffering, death, killing, and eating of non-human animals (a tortoise in the desert, a calf, butterflies, a wasp, and oysters and a dog), one questions the subject’s attitudes towards his mother, and one questions the subject’s feelings of sexual jealousy and her response to the display of another young woman’s nude body. While the latter two deviate from the theme of the subject’s attitude towards non-human animals, they both concern themes (maternity, childhood, sexuality) that are obviously deeply embedded in the broader question of ‘the human community’ and its members’ ‘group instinct.’ What none of the questions do is test the ability or propensity of the test subject to empathize with (other) *human beings*. Part of this is surely an intentional irony, as the lives the characters in the film lead test this particular ability again and again—and, as many have noted, it is only the Replicants who demonstrate any real ability to empathize with suffering creatures, or indeed any vibrant emotional life.²⁰ But it is also quite

¹⁸ In the book Deckard is usually referred to as ‘Rick,’ a practice I shall follow here to indicate the distinction between the film and the book.

¹⁹ It is significant that these reflections help Rick make his job ‘palatable,’ and allow him to respond to his wife’s claim (with which the book opens) that he is “‘a murderer hired by the cops’” (Dick 2007, 435). His understanding of what the Voigt-Kampff Empathy Test tests helps him see the androids he hunts as inherently vicious, murderous creatures. ‘*You shall kill only the killers,*’ he tells himself, and he thinks of this as really ‘retiring’ them rather than killing them (Dick 2007, 456). Though Dick begins his novel by raising the question whether this defense is adequate, he seems to have shared Rick’s feelings, and contrasted his view with Scott’s, saying ‘to me, the replicants are deplorable. . . . They are essentially less than human entities’ (cited in Bukatman 1997, 68).

²⁰ Conscience too seems to be peculiar to the Replicants. In his conversation with Tyrell, Roy confesses to doing ‘questionable things.’ But Tyrell dismisses this, and replies, ‘Also extraordinary things. Revel in your time!’ to which Roy in turn replies grimly, ‘Nothing the god of biomechanics wouldn’t let you in heaven for.’

striking, given the fact that the idea of empathy is usually used (outside of the film and the book) to characterize aspects of relations *between people*, and not between people and non-human animals or the broader natural world. The move away from this aspect of the concept serves to subtly shift the focus of the empathy test, and the focus of the film, from the sorts of questions that a different empathy test—one focussing on the subject’s ability to empathize with human beings—might raise.

The latter sort of test is what a viewer versed in the history of philosophy would expect. The concept of *empathy* as something distinct from (if nonetheless related to) *sympathy* is a development of the late 19th and early 20th century. It is most closely associated with the German philosopher Theodor Lipps (1851-1914). Lipps initially developed the concept of empathy or *Einfühlung* to address issues in philosophical aesthetics, but he soon called upon it in an effort to develop a more satisfactory response to the question of our knowledge of the existence of other minds than the so-called argument from analogy. In *An Examination of Sir William Hamilton’s Philosophy*, John Stuart Mill had asked, ‘By what evidence do I know . . . that there exist other sentient creatures; that the walking and speaking figures which I see and hear, have sensations and thoughts, or in other words, possess Minds?’ (Mill 1889, 243; cited in Malcolm 1971, 17). Mill’s answer appealed to the analogies between his own minded behavior and the behavior of others with bodies resembling his: because these other creatures manifested the sort of behaviour that he knew in his own case to be caused by mental states, he felt justified in inferring that they possessed minds as well. Lipps argued that this argument did not explain its basic assumption, which is that the *I* can in principle derive a generic conception of mind from its particular and apparently unique experience (Jahoda 2005, 156). What *I am* is in essence minded, subjective experience; and what is not me (or, more accurately, given the exclusivity of subjective experience, not I), is not.²¹ Because, as the argument from analogy assumes, I have direct knowledge of only my own mind, there is no reason to believe that I would be able to develop a generic concept of mind prior to ‘learning’ that others have minds as well; hence behaviour that recalls my minded behaviour will do only that—recall *my* minded behaviour. As Lipps puts it in ‘Das Wissen von Fremden Ich,’ the argument from analogy requires ‘entertaining a completely new thought about an I, that however is not me, but something absolutely different’—as his title has it, a ‘strange or foreign I’ (Lipps 1907, 708; cited in Stueber 2008). Lipps argues that we can nonetheless be confident that others have minds because we do not need to *infer* this fact, but can directly *perceive* it

²¹ Stueber 2008 notes that Lipps here makes the same Cartesian assumption that Mill does, and that, because of this, Lipps’ central argument against the argument from analogy is better made in Wittgenstein 1958.

by virtue of our ability to empathize with or *feel into* (*ein fühlen*) one another.²²

If the empathy test in *Blade Runner* tested the subject's ability to empathize with human beings in this manner, this would implicitly close down the problem of other minds.²³ If human beings could feel into one another's minds as Lipps claims they do, and if the authorities in the world of the film were so confident of this fact as to rest the distinction between human and Replicant upon the presence or absence of this ability, what grounds could be left for the skeptic's doubts? Mill's question would be readily answered: the evidence is in one's perception of the matter, much as with the questions, 'How do I know there is a desk in front of me?' or 'How do I know music is playing in the next room?' By pointedly not relying upon a supposed human ability to empathize with one another and hence to identify which beings are and are not minded (which beings can and cannot be felt into), the film leaves Mill's question open. Among other things, this puts in a different light Deckard and Bryant's apparent lack of interest in the criterion or criteria that would allow one to actually distinguish between human and Replicant: instead of betraying a simple lack of interest in the real distinction between the two, it reveals the possibility of a silent acknowledgment of the fact that they—and the viewers—may soon confront a situation in which they must decide for themselves, on the basis of no established criterion or criteria, who is and who is not minded, and, by extension, who is and who is not 'within the human community.' On this account, the imminent failure of the Voigt-Kampff test opens us up to a scene in which the skeptic's doubts about other minds lose their hypothetical quality, and become quite *live* questions. Lacking the ability that Lipps named empathy, the Blade Runner must, ironically enough, test the empathy of others--not, here, in Lipps' sense, but in that of their sensitivity to a now perished natural world populated by non-human animals. And he must do this so as to ensure himself that they are like him—though, as Deckard's silence in the face of Rachel's question whether he has himself ever taken the Voigt-Kampff test suggests, he does not know if he himself would 'pass' the test.

It may seem odd to refer to the other minds problem losing its hypothetical quality here, especially given that I have already argued that the Replicants quite evidently *are* minded creatures. But this ambiguity is one that is fully of a piece with the uncanny quality of skepticism, particularly the skeptical problem of other minds. The skeptic, after all, is a

²² Lipps unfortunately does not explain how or why this is possible.

²³ It would also remove a significant opportunity to highlight what Rick thought of as a function of the 'double-edged quality' of empathy, the 'shadow' that falls on all if any living being suffers. The test as it is seen in the film serves as a potent reminder that the wider natural world is dying, and that the animals with which it asks the test subject to empathize are in fact absent if not extinct. We shall return to this.

man like other men. He has colleagues, friends, perhaps a lover, perhaps a wife and children. He does not, as it is often put, *live* his skepticism. The classic statement of this inability is Hume's. Hume reports that, while reason cannot dispel his skeptical doubts, nature herself does:

I dine, I play a game of back-gammon, I converse, and am merry with my friends; and when after three or four hour's amusement, I wou'd return to these speculations, they appear so cold, and strain'd, and ridiculous, that I cannot find in my heart to enter into them any further. (Hume 1978, 269)

But this is a transformation he undergoes out in the world of other people; in his study, things are quite different, and Hume is plunged into melancholy and despair in the course of his skeptical reflections:

I am at first affrighted and confounded with that forlorn solitude, in which I am plac'd in my philosophy, and fancy myself some strange uncouth monster, who not being able to mingle and unite in society, has been expell'd all human commerce, and left utterly abandon'd and disconsolate. . . . Where am I, or what? From what causes do I derive my existence, and to what condition shall I return? Whose favor shall I court, and whose anger must I dread? What beings surround me? And on whom have I any influence, or who have any influence on me? I am confounded with all these questions, and begin to fancy myself in the most deplorable condition imaginable, environ'd with the deepest darkness, and utterly depriv'd of the use of every member and faculty. (Hume 1978, 264 and 269)

Here Hume *does* live his skepticism, if only briefly. His inability to secure the knowledge he seeks terrifies him, and leaves him disconsolate and alone. The problem he faces is not simply an intellectual puzzle. To the question, 'What beings surround me?' he has no satisfactory answer—and this, although Hume is the most sociable of creatures. It is not as if Hume *forgets* what he knows of the world and of other people; it is rather that this knowledge is no longer enough, that it loses its force and weight. Deckard is in a similar situation vis-à-vis other minds, not just when he is engaged in solitary philosophical reflection, but when he is out in the world with others—as if the darkened streets of the city had themselves taken on the quality of Hume's study, the deepest darkness with which he is 'environ'd.'

Even if this is accepted, however, there are reasons to hesitate before accepting the idea that *Blade Runner* stages a drama that might be helpfully understood in terms of the problem of other minds. The most significant of these is the fact that Deckard himself plainly *is* capable of empathizing with others and apparently can tell, all along, who is minded. When the film begins, Deckard has retired from serving as a Blade Runner. No explicit explanation is ever given, but there is a strong implication that it is because

he could not stand ‘retiring’ Replicants, a job that, as he says to Rachel, gives him the shakes.²⁴ When he learns that Rachel is a Replicant who is only beginning to suspect that she is not human, he asks, in disbelief and almost disgust, ‘How can *it* not know what it is?’ But he does not long maintain the belief that Rachel is a thing, an ‘it,’ if indeed he ever does. When Rachel appears at his apartment, he is clearly traumatized just at her being there, and first slams the door in her face, only to open it again in obvious distress. When he then recounts the proof that she is not human—the dreams she thought were private to her—he is clearly unhappy: bitter, almost angry, at the situation into which she (and he with her) has been put, the pitiful ruins of her dream of ‘her’ mother in the photo she treasures.²⁵ His awkward apology, that it is all a bad joke, is simply incomprehensible from the perspective of one who takes her, as a Replicant, to be an ‘it.’²⁶ As he has at this point had no intimate encounters with her, it seems to follow that he has struggled with these sorts of feelings for some time, and that they are at least a significant part of the reason for his ‘retirement.’ Deckard, we can conclude, is one character who does not face Mill’s problem. And it is not obvious that he is an exception in the film. No doubt, Deckard is clearly unlike, say, Bryant (the only character to refer to Replicants as ‘skin jobs’) in his sensitivity on these matters. But Bryant too seems to know much of what Deckard does. At the very least, he and his colleagues know that the Replicants not only manifest the behavior and dispositions of sentient creatures, but that they have emotions and enduring identities.²⁷ Given all of this, what would be left of the problem of other minds?

This objection is compounded by the conviction on the part of at least some viewers that *knowledge* of being minded or being human is not what is at issue in the film, but rather the *meaning* of these matters. In his helpful book on *Blade Runner*, Scott Bukatman contrasts two binary oppositions, that of human/android and that of human/inhuman, and argues that while the first is ultimately unimportant, the second is an urgent matter: ‘The division between human and android raises a central philosophical question; how do you *know* you’re human? The second opposition leads to a moral problem: what does it *mean* to be human?’ (Bukatman 1997, 68-9). For Bukatman, the second is ‘deeper and more urgent,’ and the former is, in the end, only a ‘narrative vehicle’ for it (Bukatman 1997, 70). In many

²⁴ This fact about Deckard assumes even more significance if one concludes from his conversation with Bryant (in which the latter describes the development of the NEXUS 6 Replicants’ emotional life and the institution of four year life spans as if all of this is entirely new to Deckard) that he has never before (knowingly) dealt with such sophisticated Replicants.

²⁵ Deckard also seems almost shocked or outraged when he realizes that Tyrell has given the Replicants memories that are not their ‘own.’

²⁶ One does not apologize to a toaster, no matter how badly one may have mishandled it.

²⁷ Thereby fulfilling not just the criteria proposed by Gilbert Ryle in Ryle 1949 but also the criteria for the higher standard of mental experience.

ways this seems perfectly right: what is truly interesting in both the book and the film is the moral question of humanity, of how one might lose or regain it, not the qualities of imaginary robots or synthetic organic beings, or the question of how to design tests identifying such beings. And yet, Bukatman's contrast is drawn a bit too sharply. After all, asking for the meaning of a descriptive/evaluative term like *human* is pointless if one believes it impossible in principle to identify characters or behaviours that meet those resulting criteria or standards, or fail to. This is not to deny that there may be ambiguous cases, or indeed that all cases may be more or less ambiguous; only to insist that the moral question of the meaning of humanity is one that has to be asked by someone who doubts their own humanity, or the humanity of others, and wants to be free of such doubts, for better or worse. Conversely, one cannot *know* one is human without knowing what that might *mean*; if one knows only roughly, this just means that the learning of further details of the meaning of humanity might lead one to conclude that one is not, after all, human.²⁸ This is a trivial possibility, unless there is reason to believe that one does not, in fact, know what it is to be human. But this is precisely the possibility that is raised so vividly by sentient, minded creatures who are assumed not to be human, and who cannot be human for the world of *Blade Runner* to operate as it does. (If Replicants are human, Blade Runners cannot 'retire' them.)

In this context, one is struck again by Deckard's initial deep discomfort with Rachel when she comes to his apartment, his desire to keep her out, and his reluctant opening of the door to her only after slamming it in her face. If Deckard knows that Rachel has a mind, this is a knowledge that he plainly *resists*. One might say that he is not ready, at the start of the film, to accept or acknowledge what he already knows, that the 'retiring' of Replicants is murder, that they are not automatons who can be shut on and off like electric clocks, but sentient creatures who experience pain and, further, have enduring identities and characters.²⁹ (As distasteful as Bryant is, one might also suspect that his constant reference to the Replicants as 'skin jobs' is itself a way of keeping this knowledge at bay, of asserting in its face that they are not human, that killing them is and can only be a matter

²⁸ Bukatan notes that Dick had been preoccupied by the Third Reich when writing *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* He quotes Dick: 'With the Nazis, what we were dealing with was a defective group mind, a mind so emotionally defective that the word "human" could not be applied to it' (Bukatman 1997, 68). On this account—which seems perfectly compatible with the film, though with the roles as it were reversed, the humans now playing the Nazis—someone one had known to be a human being (e.g., Joseph Goebbels) turns out not to be human, in the fullest sense of the term.

²⁹ Bukatman suggests that, for the film, '*what has feelings is human*' (Bukatman 1997, 69), but this is surely too broad. The film does not mount a utilitarian, Peter Singer-style defense of the Replicants (least of all animals) as beings that have moral worth because of their feelings, but, as Bukatman himself emphasizes, a much deeper *questioning* of the grounds upon which any such claim might be made.

of retiring a ‘killing machine.’³⁰) This plainly does not fit the problem of other minds as conceived by Mill and Lipps. It is, however, close indeed to that advanced by Stanley Cavell. On Cavell’s account, skepticism regarding our knowledge of other minds of the sort ‘refuted’ (indirectly) by Mill and (directly) by Lipps is best thought of neither as an accurate nor a false account of the actual situation in which the philosopher finds himself, but rather as a *deflection* of the claims that others make upon him, a refusal to acknowledge them, much like Deckard’s initial refusal to let in the miserable Rachel. It will be worth our while to parse out these claims.

As is plain in Mill’s statement of the ‘problem,’ the skeptic takes himself to begin in a state in which he alone is minded, and in which he does not know if the other—to use the classic example from the literature—is in pain, sentient, conscious, or minded. ‘No doubt,’ the skeptic says to himself, ‘all of the external criteria for being in pain are met—she grips the injured part of her body, grimaces, rocks back and forth, moans lowly, and so on—but the satisfaction of these criteria still do not prove that she really *feels pain* now, in the way that *I* do when *I* am injured.’ To really know that the other is in pain, the skeptic dissatisfied, like Lipps, with Mill’s inference from external evidence wants to actually *perceive* this, to feel, as it were, the other’s pain. (Wittgenstein remarks, in a passage which lies behind Cavell’s discussion, ‘I have seen a person in a discussion on this subject strike himself on the breast and say: ‘But surely another person [*der Andre*] can’t have THIS pain!’ [Wittgenstein 1958, I §253]). But what, Cavell asks, would this entail? In an early essay, “Knowing and Acknowledging,” Cavell imagines a pair of brothers, one of whom, Second, suffers everything which happens to his brother First. Cavell emphasizes that the second brother feels pain *because* the first feels it: the pain is First’s. While this might seem to be a picture that would satisfy the skeptic, the very manner in which the second brother feels the first’s pain makes it doubtful that it will. Everything hinges on whether either brother could be said to *know* the other is in pain. Cavell finds that he at least would not say this:

First’s knowledge is ‘too intellectual’: even though he has the same pain as Second, he has to ‘infer’ (or remember?) that Second is in pain. So the phenomenological pang in having to say that knowing another mind is a matter of inference [as in Mill] remains after we have granted what seemed to be lacking in our knowledge of the other. In the latter case (Second knowing First), Second’s knowledge is ‘too immediate’; his ‘having’ First’s pain is, one might say, an effect of that pain, not a response to it. (Cavell 1969b, 253)

³⁰ As many have remarked, the phrase ‘skin jobs’ associates the Replicant slaves with the black American slaves and their descendants. Here too, racist language can serve as a ‘cushion’ or justification for the unpleasant implications of one’s racism. Seeing blacks as *niggers* makes their plight appear less distressing, less blatantly unjust.

In the first case, First does feel Second's pain, but recalls that Second feels it; in the second, the pain is felt by Second in so 'immediate' a fashion that it ceases being First's, and becomes Second's own. Cavell concludes that the idea of knowing the other's pain as being a matter of experiencing something oneself as opposed to *responding* to another's experience is misguided, as is the skeptic's claim that he cannot know the other's pain. The skeptic's initial denial that he knows that the other is in pain is, as Cavell sees it, a response to the vulnerability of that knowledge and the demands it places upon him. As he puts it in *The Claim of Reason*,

To withhold, or hedge, our concepts of psychological states from a given creature, on the ground that our criteria cannot reach the inner life of the creature, is specifically to withhold the source of my idea that living beings are things that feel; it is to withhold myself, to reject my response to anything as a living being; to blank so much as my idea of anything as *having a body*. To describe *this* condition as one in which I do not know (am not certain) of the existence of other minds, is empty. There is nothing there, of the right kind, to be known. (Cavell 1979a, 83-4)

But if the skeptic's demands for more knowledge of the other are empty, this does not, for Cavell, imply that there is no knowledge here. Indeed, Cavell goes so far as to argue, 'I know your pain the way you do' (Cavell 1969b, 266). Given the discussion of the brothers First and Second, Cavell is clearly not proposing that he knows you are in pain by feeling your pain. Rather, his point is that he can say he knows you are in pain in the same circumstances in which you can. On the basis of his ordinary language analysis of the conditions of making such an assertion in a meaningful fashion (Cavell 1969a and Cavell 1969c), Cavell argues that such circumstances do not often occur: saying 'I know I am in pain' is not the usual way of expressing or even reporting that I am in pain, and it would, in most contexts, be unclear what it might *mean* to say that. One context in which it would not be unclear (or outright senseless) would be that which I am struggling to *deny* that (or what) I am suffering. In these circumstances, saying 'I know I'm in pain' might be a way of *acknowledging* what I am feeling (Cavell 1969b, 255-6). Conversely, the other might say, 'I know you are in pain' when pressing me to make such an acknowledgment--or acknowledging my pain herself. That is to say, the meaningful assertion of the knowledge of pain occurs in the context of acknowledging the other, of being acknowledged oneself, and of acknowledging feelings that we seek to deny. 'In making the knowledge of others a metaphysical difficulty,' Cavell remarks, 'philosophers deny how real the practical difficulty is of coming to know another person, and how little we can reveal of ourselves to another's gaze, or bear of it. Doubtless such denials are part of the motive which sustains metaphysical difficulties' (Cavell 1979a, 90).

I would argue that this is a better fit with Deckard's situation than is either the account of Mill or the account that asserts that Mill's questions are simply irrelevant to the film. Deckard is not quite ignorant of the fact that Rachel is in deep pain, that she is minded, that she can be murdered, but he does not quite know these things, either. (Cavell speaks in this regard of 'the truth of skepticism' [Cavell 1979a, 241].) Neither Mill's suggestion that we need an argument from analogy nor Lipps' denial of the same are quite right. Deckard, instead, is a man faced with a knowledge that he does not want to accept, with a miserable person whom he does not want to acknowledge, with a relationship for which he does not want to be responsible, with an inhuman world that he does not want to be forced to judge. And the use of the Voigt-Kampff test is a way to deflect these burdens. In Cavell's terms, one might say that instead of taking up the task of *acknowledging* that Rachel is in pain, and confronting the responsibilities this entails, Deckard turns to a machine that will, he hopes, give him certain *knowledge*. This way of putting it may invite confusion. If Deckard does know that Rachel is in pain, but denies it, doesn't his acknowledgment of Rachel and of the fact that she is in pain entail his actively and truly *knowing* that she is in pain? And in that case, isn't Deckard correct to seek the knowledge that Rachel is in pain, viz., is minded? The pertinent question, however, is how and where this knowledge is sought, what kind of knowledge is felt to be lacking.³¹ The other minds skeptic seeks this knowledge in some mark or sign from or in the other: the other must prove herself, or proof must be provided for her. The Cavellian response is to insist that no such mark—even a mark that fit all of the skeptic's criteria (as in his discussion of the brothers First and Second, the pain of the other that one feels for oneself)—could in principle satisfy the skeptic, as the search for it is a deflection from a knowledge that the skeptic denies—that is, fails to acknowledge. The mark or sign is rather one that the skeptic himself must give, the test one he himself must pass. The demand for knowledge that reaches beyond the criteria Deckard (and we) already possesses—is precisely the avoidance of this test. Where a (human) response is called for, one seeks instead knowledge of facts and categories, and a reliable method to obtain the same.³² If Hume is saved from the terrors and isolation of his

³¹ Cavell explains, 'I do not propose the idea of acknowledgment as an alternative to knowing but rather as an interpretation of it, as I take the word 'acknowledge,' containing 'knowledge,' itself to suggest (or perhaps it suggests that knowing is an interpretation of acknowledging)' (Cavell 1988, 8); 'acknowledgment' is the mode in which knowledge of mind appears' (Cavell 1979b, 239).

³² Cavell's analysis follows that of Heidegger's *Being and Time*, as Cavell indicates when he describes his category of *acknowledgment* as the sort of concept Heidegger calls an *existentiale* (*Existenzial*), that is, like authenticity, a concept appropriate for explicating the being of Da-sein as opposed to the categories (*Kategorien*) appropriate to modes of being like that of chairs, tables, and so on (Cavell 1969b, 263-4). 'It is,' Heidegger writes, 'not a matter of proving that and how an "external world" is objectively present, but of demonstrating why Da-sein as being-in-the-world has the tendency of "initially" burying

skeptical thoughts by immersing himself in the social world, Deckard seeks to escape the burdens of his responsibilities to others—his need to respond to Rachel’s misery—in a skeptical pursuit of knowledge.³³ (Here we see another possible significance of the fact that the machine used to administer the test breathes: it is precisely a mechanical means for pretending to confront the life of the other.) Deckard’s coming to see this, to accept the knowledge he already possesses, is a central part of the drama of the film; and at the heart of this passage, this testing of Deckard, is the moment in which he opens the door to Rachel, and opens himself to her and to the anguish she feels at what she has learned of herself.³⁴

‘The Fires of Orc’: Corporate Slaves and Rebels

It is crucial for our understanding of the film to see that these issues are presented in a very particular context, one that could not be more different from the usual setting in which they are raised (e.g., a philosophy seminar or faculty common room). What it means to be minded in this film’s world, and what it means to resist acknowledging the minded status of others, is bound up with a set of political, moral, and economic factors that make the life of the Replicant deeply repulsive, and that hopelessly compromise the lives of those whom they serve. Central to these is the fact that the

the “external world” in nullity “epistemologically” in order first to prove it. The reason for this lies in the falling prey of Da-sein and in the diversion motivated therein of the primary understanding of being to the being of objective presence’; and, ‘A skeptic can no more be refuted than the being of truth can ever be “proved.” If the skeptic, who denies the truth, factually *is*, he does *not even need* to be refuted. Insofar as he *is* and has understood himself in this being [as being a skeptic and hence as not being the site of the disclosure of truth], he has obliterated Da-sein, and thus truth, in the despair of suicide. The necessity of truth cannot be proven because Da-sein cannot first be subjected to proof for its own part’ (Heidegger, 1996, 191 and 210).

³³ I do not mean to suggest by this contrast that Hume advances an approach to skepticism that anticipates Cavell’s. Space, however, does not permit me to describe the critique that Cavell might make of Hume’s own skepticism.

³⁴ Alice Crary has also noted that *Blade Runner* ‘invites us to acknowledge the humanity of its nonhuman androids’ (Crary 2007, 403). On Crary’s account, this invitation is one that we can accept because the concept *human* is capable, in a term she borrows silently from Cavell, of being ‘projected’ into new usages; and this in turn is possible because ‘the conceptual practices here envisioned involve not our biological concepts “human” and “animal” but rather nonbiological concepts “human” and “animal” that . . . need not be coextensive with their biological concepts’ (Crary 2007, 398). Crary follows Cora Diamond in arguing that significant ‘objective’ moral obligations flow from the practice of using and appealing to the non-biological concept of the human (and the animal), such that understanding the concept *human* entails that one grasp what is and is not permissible to do with a human being or a human being’s body (e.g., one may not hunt a human being for entertainment, or eat a human body). Crary’s account is a convincing one, and her argument that the relevant concept of the human being is not a biological one seems correct and helpful. But perhaps because her focus is on Diamond’s discussion of the moral aspects of our relations with animals, Crary takes up, to my way of thinking, the wrong end of the problem. That is, her concern is with how we might put ourselves in the position to extend the term *human* to Replicant supplicants. But this, I have argued, *is* the skeptical fantasy. Deckard’s problem is not that of justifying to himself such an extension, but acknowledging what he already knows.

Replicants are *creatures* in the literal sense of the term, though they are not the creations of God or nature. Whose creations are they? An obvious answer is, Dr. Eldon Tyrell's. Certainly the scene where Roy visits and then murders Tyrell emphasizes the manner in which the paternal relation between Tyrell and his creation replicates that between the Christian God and the creature made in His image.³⁵ Tyrell is delighted to meet Roy, as in him he sees evidence of who he wants to be: a godlike creator (albeit one who, the viewer notes, has just risen from bed, where he sat making decisions on his investments). This lends a deep ambiguity to Roy's murder of his creator, and to Roy himself. On the one hand, this murder is the act that most dramatically casts Roy as a figure of horror; on the other, given how closely the Christian tradition aligns human freedom with mankind's sinful rebellion against its creator and His laws, it is the moment at which the viewer can most readily identify with Roy as a free agent (cf., e.g., Augustine 1993, 69). The introduction of such important themes plainly requires a personal creator such as Tyrell. However, this is not the only account we are given of the constitution of the Replicants. Though we are told that only Tyrell understands the full mysteries of the Replicants--such as 'Morphology, Longevity, and Incept Dates'--we are also told in the first sentence of the short passage with which the film opens that it is not he but the commercially driven Tyrell *Corporation* that 'advanced Robot evolution into the NEXUS phase,' the phase where the company motto, 'More human than human' might be realized.³⁶ And there are good reasons to give priority to this second account: first, because this passage provides the context within which all that follows it is to be understood; and, second, because this passage is the only moment in which anyone other than a character in the film speaks--as if Plato rather than Socrates provided the context within which the reader should consider the conversation recounted in the *Republic*. If this is often overlooked, it is because the opening passage seems to be merely the frame of the story, rather than part of the film. But that, of course, is just the point. And there is, finally, an obvious sense in which only the Tyrell Corporation could create the Replicants; and that is that Tyrell's genius alone could never produce them in the absence of

³⁵ It is deeply significant that this is the sole image of paternity in a film that returns repeatedly to the maternal, as in Leon's initial explosion in response to Holden's questions about his mother, and in Rachel's misery at the loss of the mother in her picture, and the 'memory' she has of watching a mother spider being eaten alive by her progeny.

³⁶ The entire passage reads, 'Early in the 21st Century, THE TYRELL CORPORATION advanced Robot evolution into the NEXUS phase--a being virtually identical to a human--known as a Replicant. The NEXUS 6 Replicants were superior in strength and agility, and at least equal in intelligence, to the genetic engineers who created them. Replicants were used Off-world as slave labour, in the hazardous exploration and colonization of other planets. After a bloody mutiny by a NEXUS 6 combat team in an Off-world colony, Replicants were declared illegal on earth -- under penalty of death. Special police squads--BLADE RUNNER UNITS--had orders to shoot to kill, upon detection, any trespassing Replicants. This was not called execution. It was called retirement.'

the assistance of ‘under-labourers’ like Hannibal Chew and J.F. Sebastian, the technological apparatus and economy of scale brought by the corporation, and the demands of an interplanetary colonial power for the corporation’s products.³⁷

There is a subtle but disturbing aspect to this second account of the constitution of the Replicants. The passage we are discussing is the first time in the film in which we are given a depiction or description of an *actor* or *agent*: the advancement of Robot evolution into the NEXUS phase is the first thing we see or hear of being *done* in the film. And the actor here is a corporation, not, as we might expect, a human being. Conversely, the technological development made possible by the corporation is said to be an ‘evolution.’ It is not too much to say that the opening sentence enacts a reversal of our expectations, confounding organic life and human agency, and technological and capitalist enterprise--precisely the categorical confusion that Marx argues defines capitalism, a socio-economic system in which living labour serves accumulated, dead labour—capital—rather the reverse.³⁸ This forces us to ask, why is it that the powers dominating this world cannot tolerate the presence of Replicants? If they—or we—are comfortable with the corporation named after Dr. Eldon Tyrell (and not Tyrell himself) being the first and central actor in this story, where is the difficulty in accepting the activity of Replicants? And the answer seems to be that they are too much like us, too human to be allowed in our world. There is no possibility of confusing Tyrell and the corporation that bears his name. If the one slowly cedes the stage to the other, that in no way challenges his—or our—conception of who he is. But things are quite different with the Replicants, ‘beings’ who are said to be ‘virtually identical’ to human beings. A vision of humanity is thus implicated in the Tyrell Corporation’s control of the world of *Blade Runner*. Anxious as they are to keep that world free of the confusion of the human and the non-human, the human beings of *Blade Runner*—like the viewer--nonetheless silently accept the same confusion on another level.³⁹ What is important to them is not the actual supremacy of the ‘empathetic’ human being, but the *image* of such. So long as the image is maintained, the actual work can be

³⁷ Roy seems to know this well. When Chew tells him that he must speak with Tyrell about extending his life, as ‘he knows everything,’ he immediately responds, as if to clarify and correct, ‘Tyrell Corporation?’

³⁸ Instead of the tool being used by the worker to serve her ends, the worker is used by the machine and its owner for the purposes of accumulating more capital. ‘It is,’ as Marx puts it, ‘only the dominion of accumulated, past, materialized labour over direct, living labour that turns accumulated labour into capital. Capital does not consist in accumulated labour serving living labour as a means for new production. It consists in living labour serving accumulated labour as a means of maintaining and multiplying the exchange value of the latter’ (Marx 1978, 208-9).

³⁹ The same tendency is of course rampant in our world today; witness the recent U.S. Supreme Court case *Citizens United v. FEC*, which further strengthened the growing claims of corporations to be understood as bearing the rights of natural persons.

done by non-human agents. But images can be replicated, and slaves can be produced in the image of their vain masters.⁴⁰

And slaves are ultimately what the Replicants are.⁴¹ The world brought into being by the constituting activity of the Tyrell Corporation is above all one of industrialized slavery. It is a world in which the violent and ‘hazardous exploration and colonization of other planets’ can be pursued with minimal risk of human life, as the task of soldiering will increasingly be left to Roy and those like him. It is a world in which ‘basic pleasure models’ of the Nexus Replicant such as Pris can be made available for human use—as well as other presumably less basic pleasure models. And it is a world in which the slavery of these sentient beings is conceived of as being *total*. The slavery of the Replicants is so complete that death for them is identified in the terms of labour. They are not killed or ‘executed,’ they are *retired*: life for them *is* labour. Replicants, then, are workers before they are anything else, and they are workers in a world dominated by colonization and technologically driven, capitalist corporations. (‘More human than human’ may be the company motto, but, as Tyrell announces in response to Deckard’s question, ‘How can it not know what it is?’ ‘Commerce is our goal.’) As the title of the film indicates, *Blade Runner* is before all else a tale of the hunting and killing of escaped slaves in this world.⁴²

It is also a tale of the rebellion of those slaves. This is somewhat obscured by the fact that the band of Replicants led by Roy brave the return to earth in order to acquire ‘more life.’ But Roy makes plain that he at least also understands their action as rebellion in the name of freedom. The first words he utters to an apparently non-Replicant agent of the Tyrell Corporation, the genetic eye engineer Chew, are, ‘Fiery the angels fell. Deep thunder rode around their shores, burning with the fires of Orc.’ The line is a slight misquotation from William Blake’s 1793 poem, ‘America: A Prophecy,’ the original of which reads, ‘Fiery the Angels rose, & as they

⁴⁰ One might say that the very fascination with the human as an image leads to its use as a mirror the maker uses to see himself, which is to say, the separation of the image from what it supposedly stands. Seen in this light, the oft-remarked fascination of the Replicants with images and ‘precious photos’ hints at their humanity, rather than their lack thereof.

⁴¹ The slavery theme plays a major role in the book as well, in which ‘the ultimate incentive of emigration’ is ‘the android servant as carrot, the radioactive fallout [on Earth] as stick.’ At one point a TV set ‘shouts’ an advertisement for the off world colonies: ‘. . . duplicates the halcyon days of the pre-Civil War Southern states! Either as body servants or tireless field hands, the custom-tailored humanoid robot—designed specifically for YOUR UNIQUE NEEDS, FOR YOU AND YOU ALONE’ (Dick 2007, 445). One’s status as a unique person—a genuine human being—is asserted in one’s mastery over inhuman slaves. A version of this advertisement plays from the ship hovering above the street when Deckard, still retired from his job, is sitting down to eat.

⁴² The term *Blade Runner* was borrowed from William Burroughs’s novel of that name. In the context of the film, it has a number of connotations, chief among them (a) it serves to name a creature who walks a very thin line between the human and the inhuman, and (b) it names the vehicle for the decision to cut (*de-caedere*, to cut) the two apart from one another.

rose deep thunder roll'd/ Around their shores, indignant burning with the fires of Orc.⁴³ In the mythology of the Blake poem, written to celebrate the American Revolution, Orc is the figure representing Jesus and the youthful power of life and freedom, standing in opposition to Urizen, the Old Testament God of formalistic law and empty authority. "I am Orc," the first announces,

wreath'd round the accursed tree:
'The times are ended; shadows pass, the morning 'gins to break;
'The fiery joy, that Urizen perverted to ten commands . . .
'That stony law I stamp to dust'. (Blake 2005, 72)

In the poem, Orc's battle against Urizen is fought, in part, on the grounds of the America of the poem's title, and Orc is joined by Washington, Franklin, Paine, and other heroes of the American Revolution. Indeed, the angels to whom the misquoted lines refer are 'the thirteen Angels' representing the thirteen states of the Revolution (Blake 2005, 72). In citing him, then, Roy not only announces himself to be a lover of poetry—itself a significant fact for a 'robot'—he also announces his identification with the struggle waged by Washington, Paine, and Orc.⁴⁴ This is a struggle for liberation from far more than British rule. In the eyes of the radical Blake, it is a struggle for liberty and life against authority and empty rules.⁴⁵ One of these rules might prove to be the rule that Replicants and human beings differ in some fundamental way. The lines I cited just now condemning the ten 'commands' or commandments continue:

'For everything that lives is holy, life delights in life;
'Because the soul of sweet delight can never be defil'd.
'Fires inwrap the earthly globe, yet man is not consum'd;
'Amidst the lustful fires he walks; his feet become like brass,
'His knees and thighs like silver, & his breast and head like gold.
(Blake 2005, 72)

Blake's image of a living metallic man that can bear walking in "the fires of Orc" is almost an anticipation of an earlier evolutionary stage of 'Robot evolution' than that depicted in the film. If Roy's misquotation of the poem betrays a less hopeful attitude than Blake's--the angels falling rather than rising--it also demonstrates that he has read it enough to *remember* it rather than simply (mechanically) *record* it, as a computer or a tape recording

⁴³ The Blake line is identified but not discussed in the review and synopsis of the film by Tim Dirks at <http://www.filmsite.org/blad2.html>.

⁴⁴ Deckard too shows an appreciation for beauty, not only in his relation with Rachel, but also in the scene where he is flown to the pyramid where the Tyrell Corporation has its headquarters.

⁴⁵ The same struggle between the 'positivity' of Judaism and the 'life' of Jesus drives the early Hegel's reflections in Hegel 1975.

might. Roy thus reveals himself to be one who has weighed these issues well, and who sees both the beauty and the honour in the struggle for freedom.

What then of the forces which oppose Roy and his fellows? What of the Blade Runners who give the film its title? One of the most significant features of the 'job' of hunting and killing Replicants is that it is apparently something that only a Replicant slave can do. The NEXUS 6 Replicants are 'superior in strength and agility, and at least equal in intelligence, to the genetic engineers who created them'; what human could be counted upon to 'retire' such creatures? Only the Replicant Deckard has any hope of succeeding with the four after whom he is sent. As Bryant tells Deckard, 'I need ya, Decks. This is a bad one, the worst yet. I need the old Blade Runner, I need your magic.' But even Deckard's 'magic' is not entirely up to the task. Though he manages to kill Pris and Zhora—shooting the latter in the back—Rachel must save him from Leon, and Deckard can only watch Roy die of old age after Roy has saved his own life. Plainly, if the world that rests on the foundations laid by the Tyrell Corporation is to endure, it will require beings 'more human than human' to hunt and kill one another.⁴⁶

⁴⁶ This central feature of the society of *Blade Runner* invites comparison with that of another dystopia, that depicted in the fourth part of Swift's 1726 classic, *Gulliver's Travels*. There have been many interpretations of this part of the book, and many evaluations of the hyper-rational equine society depicted in it; but there is one aspect in which that society is plainly horrific, and that is its effect upon Gulliver. The Houyhnhnms who rule the land despise the Yahoos with whom they share it, and whom they employ as slaves; and the only matter upon which they disagree with one another enough to muster a public debate is 'whether the Yahoos should be exterminated from the Face of the Earth'—something that has already been determined about the Replicants in *Blade Runner* (Swift 2003, 249). While some have described this debate as the consideration of genocide, this accusation is questionable given that the Houyhnhnms and Yahoos are two distinct species. But Gulliver is in a quite different position: for all of his deep and abiding admiration of the Houyhnhnms, he still believes himself to be a Yahoo (Swift 2003, 245 and 262). His contempt for the species is thus a form of self-contempt, and his casual use of 'the skins of Yahoos well stitched together' to make his shoes and canoe is a horror of another order than that contemplated by the Houyhnhnms (Swift 2003, 253 and 258). Gulliver does not, however, acknowledge this at all, and he reports without further comment, 'My sail was likewise composed of the Skins of the same Animal; but I made use of the youngest I could get, the older being too tough and thick' (Swift 2003, 258). That the reader is intended to feel horror and disgust at this is plain from a comparison of Gulliver's behaviour with that recommended in Swift's bitterly ironic 1729 'Modest Proposal,' in which the wealthy are encouraged to butcher and eat the children of the Irish poor whom they so oppress. In a passage that directly recalls the details of Gulliver's blasé accounts of his making of shoes and sails, the author of the 'Proposal' writes, 'Those who are more thrifty (as I must confess the times require) may flay the carcass [of the baby]; the skin of which artificially dressed will make admirable gloves for ladies, and summer boots for fine gentlemen.' This imagery is evoked quite explicitly in Dick's novel, where Deckard refers to 'human pelts used decoratively,' and where the culminating empathy test that proves Rachel not to be human involves Deckard stroking his black leather briefcase while saying, 'Babyhide. One hundred percent genuine human babyhide' (Dick 2007, 536 and 476). The scene is absent from the movie, but Scott retains the reference by having Bryant repeatedly describe the Replicants as 'skin jobs'—something he does not do in the novel. And he comes closer to Swift than does Dick in making the job of Blade Running a matter of murdering one's own kind for pay—living off them, as it were.

The film consistently takes care to show us that the ‘retiring’ of these ‘skin jobs’ is a matter of bodies, as well as time and mind. As Roy reminds the ‘toymaker’ Sebastian, ‘We’re not computers, Sebastian, we’re physical.’ The portrayals of the deaths of these embodied beings are not without their ambiguities. In the spastic contortions of her death, Pris, in particular, resembles the automata of J.F. Sebastian’s madhouse more than she ever did in life. But this is tempered by the heartfelt tenderness Roy shows to her dead body, kissing her, caressing her, wiping his face with her blood, and tenderly putting her tongue back into her mouth to give her dignity in death. Leon (like the Blade Runner Holden) dies the death of a character in a typical action movie, but this too is tempered by the horror Rachel feels at having had to shoot and kill him, and Deckard’s confession that he too gets ‘the shakes’ from killing Replicants. The long, slow-motion death of Zhora, on the other hand, dwells almost obsessively on her body as, clad in a transparent raincoat, it smashes through a series of glass barriers, only, finally, to collapse into a bloody heap. The stark contrast between the transparency surrounding her and the density and opacity of her corpse suggest a limit to the powers of the administered world that made her: where the nominally private apartments of Sebastian and Deckard are constantly probed by the lights of the outside world, and, while in life her thoughts were only in a questionable sense her own, her body used and displayed for the pleasure of others, in death it is shown at last to be hers alone.

In light of all this, it is little wonder that Deckard is as anxious as he is to resist acknowledging Rachel and the truth about her. To do so demands not simply shouldering the responsibilities of a human relationship with her, it requires acknowledging what kind of world he inhabits, how it is governed, and what kind of life it makes possible. More, acknowledging Rachel entails that Deckard see that, if she is like him, he is like her, that he is one of *them* in some basic sense.⁴⁷ What he learns is not that Replicants are minded, but that he too is a creature in a world of men who would be gods, of corporations which produce mortal slaves who will be forced to hunt one another and live off of one another, who will be used for the pleasure of others, and who, in all of their suffering, are stranded in an uncanny no man’s land in which their feelings are both their own and not their own. Who would not prefer to evade all of this by trusting mechanical tests and shutting others out?

⁴⁷ Deckard may not yet know himself to be a Replicant when he makes love to Rachel, but by this point he has clearly begun to abandon the belief that there is a difference between them that makes a difference. In a scene that remained unfilmed, another Blade Runner tells Deckard, ‘You might as well go fuck your washing machine’ (Bukatman 1997, 71). This is plainly not (no longer) Deckard’s own view.

‘But then again, who does?’: Mortality and Community

If Deckard’s relationship with Rachel is at the heart of his coming to acknowledge all of this, it is equally clear that this relationship alone is not enough to effect the change he undergoes over the course of the film. For one thing, Deckard continues to serve as a Blade Runner after he begins his relationship with Rachel, and only finally quits his job and flees the city at the close of the film. For another, the quality of that relationship deepens perceptibly over the course of the second half of the film. Where in their initial erotic encounter, he is disturbingly violent with her, physically forcing her to stay in his apartment, telling her what to say to him, and demanding that she announce her desire for him—in short, treating her in a manner that evokes the slavery for which she was made—in their final scene together he tenderly kisses her, and *asks* her whether she loves and trusts him. More subtly, he silently listens to her breathing, attentive to her as a *living* being in the most direct way possible. This change is due to Deckard’s encounter with Roy, the climactic scene in the film.⁴⁸ Where a more typical science fiction fantasy casts romantic and/or erotic relationships as themselves the proper counter to a future world gone mad, in *Blade Runner* such relationships must be experienced in terms of what Deckard learns from Roy.⁴⁹ To appreciate what kind of scene this concluding one is, it is helpful to recall that the very first scene of the film depicts Leon being put through the Voigt-Kampff empathy test. Roy’s encounter with Deckard is another kind of test. One might say that the film moves us from one empathy test to another, and that the bulk of the film is a demonstration, from various perspectives, of why this change in ‘test’ must be made. Here, in the film’s climax, the test is part of a series of exercises or lessons structured to help Deckard *learn* who he, Deckard, is, to teach him what the Replicants whom he hunts and kills experience, to show him what their fear and death is and means.⁵⁰ As terrifying as Roy is in the final chase, he not only saves Deckard’s life in the end, he never seriously tries to take it. Indeed, the only time he tries to injure Deckard at all is when he

⁴⁸ Some may find this a contentious claim. But it is certain that the encounter with Roy *does* change Deckard, and that Scott has not shown the viewer what in the relationship between Deckard and Rachel would account for his very different treatment of her.

⁴⁹ See in this regard Godard’s *Alphaville*, which anticipates *Blade Runner*’s sci-fi noir, and which culminates in Natacha’s break with the world of Alphaville in simply saying, ‘Je vous aime’ (Godard, 1965); or Orwell’s *1984*, in which ‘[n]ot love so much as eroticism was the enemy [of the Party]’ (Orwell 1949, 57); or William Menzies’ *Invaders from Mars*, in which little David is saved by the trust and intuitive understanding shown by the beautiful Dr. Pat Blake.

⁵⁰ This obviously characterizes the film as a whole, to the extent that the viewer identifies with the main character, Deckard. Late in his life, Abraham Lincoln joked in a speech, ‘While I have often said that all men ought to be free, yet I would allow those colored persons to be slaves who want to be; and next to them those white persons who argue in favor of making other people slaves. I am in favor of giving an opportunity to such white men to try it on for themselves’ (Lincoln 2009, 351). One might say that *Blade Runner* offers precisely this opportunity, to Deckard, and to us.

breaks two of his fingers before letting him go—and even this is a kind of demonstration: contrary to whatever Deckard may assume about Replicants, they do care for one another, they do avenge one another, and in a proportionate manner, and they do mourn one another.⁵¹

In this context we can appreciate a crucial aspect of the Voigt-Kampff test's emphasis upon the subject's empathetic response to non-human animal life, and Rick's speculations that the ability to empathize with such animals is tied to a broader connection to the natural world. No such animals exist in the film, and the natural world itself has been entirely effaced by a man-made urban nightmare. A test that focuses upon one's feelings for extinct species, dead animals, and a dead world is almost a test that gauges one's ability to *mourn*. Recognizing this in turn highlights the fact that Roy is the first character shown to mourn another, when he tearfully if hastily prepares Pris' dead body. When Roy saves Deckard, it is order to allow Deckard to watch him, Roy, die. And when he watches this, Deckard not only stares in wonder and amazement, but closes his eyes in sorrow, himself mourning for perhaps the first time.⁵² Roy's poetic last words are hardly those of a computer program losing power: 'I've seen things you people wouldn't believe. Attack ships on fire off the shoulder of Orion. I watched C-beams glitter in the dark near the Tannhauser gate. All those moments will be lost in time . . . like tears in rain . . . Time to die.' Roy here repeats--or replicates--Leon's earlier threat to Deckard, 'Wake up. Time to die,' but does so in a manner which reveals an essential humanity. This is in part a function of the almost maudlin seriousness with which his death is depicted, with the dove symbolizing his soul flying away in the rain. But it is also because these final words demonstrate such a sensitive grasp of the reliance of his, and our, identity upon the capacity to endure in time. The first words Roy utters in the film are, 'Time enough.' A machine is temporal to the extent that it can work more or less quickly—'reaction time is a factor'—and that it can wear out, a process that may be either gradual or abrupt. In contrast, a Replicant lives in time in the sense that it can develop as well as degenerate; and it does not wear out, but *dies*. It is not simply *limited* by the imperfections of the material of which it is made; it is, rather, a *mortal* being.

Immediately before saving Deckard's life, Roy asks him, 'Quite an experience to live in fear, isn't it? That's what it is to be a slave.' This too is an echo of Leon, here of Leon asking Deckard, 'Painful to live in fear, isn't it?' while he is attempting to kill him. Roy can repeat the question, again, without the threat, because he adds an empathetic note of instruction.

⁵¹ For the two lives he takes in the film, Deckard has two fingers broken, but he is also saved twice, first by Rachel and then by Roy.

⁵² Certainly for the first time in the film. If Deckard does anything like mourning Zhora and Leon, he does not experience this *as* mourning, but as drinking away 'the shakes.'

The Replicants are slaves in the deepest sense not because of the work they do, but because they work in the face of a dreaded death. For all of the film's obvious debts to Shelley's *Frankenstein*, its depiction of a created, artificial human being does not share the novel's concern with 'the change from life to death, and death to life.' No figure in the film could say of life and death what Frankenstein says, that they are 'ideal bounds, which I should first break through, and pour a torrent of light into our dark world' (Shelley 1988, 53 and 54). No doubt, when Roy asks Tyrell to extend his life, there is at least the possibility that this extension might be open-ended. But nothing is made of this, and death remains the final limit for all of the central characters in the film. It is in the shadow of this limit that their lives attain the meaning they do. The moments Roy speaks of losing in the rain are nothing but memories, and as such, according to the logic of the film, they might well be nothing more than 'implants.' But this, it seems, is in the end of no importance. One's past becomes one's own in so far as it makes up the identity of the mortal being facing death. Without any identity at all, death could not come: one would simply expire. But when it does come, the source, in the past, of one's memories and one's self falls away. In the end, we—like Roy—are futurally directed beings, whose past means what it does because of what awaits us in the future—that death which, as Heidegger puts it, is our 'ownmost' (*eigenste*), but which we must seize and make our own (*sich zueigen*) by acknowledging and accepting it as a crucial part of who we as mortal creatures are, rather than an external accident that may for some reason someday sadly befall us (Heidegger 1996, 242 and Heidegger 2001, 263 and 240).⁵³ As Gaff calls, in the final lines of the film: 'It's too bad she won't live! But then again, who does?'

⁵³ Slavoj Žižek has famously argued that *Blade Runner* cannot be aligned with the early Heidegger in this manner, and should instead be understood in terms of Descartes and Lacan. 'Replicants,' he writes, 'know their life span is limited to four years. This certainty saps the openness of their "being-towards death"' (Žižek 1993, 42). I have indicated above why the film does not fit well with the specifics of Descartes' engagement with scepticism; space does not permit an adequate discussion of the Lacanian aspects of Žižek's discussion. On the current point, it is crucial to recall that Heidegger emphasizes that the certainty (*Gewißheit*) Da-sein possesses of its death is radically different from the certainty it possesses of facts such as those concerning the objective presence of the objects before it. It is a certainty that comes to Da-sein through the *Angst* it feels in the face of the constant and continual (*ständig*) possibility of its death. When one might die is '*ständig unbestimmt*' in the sense that one might die at any time; as Heidegger puts it, Da-sein faces a '*ständige Bedrohung*,' a constant threat. The time of one's death is undetermined not in the sense that one might live forever, but in the sense that one must continually live in the face of that possibility (Heidegger 2001, 265). As Heidegger emphasizes, 'what is peculiar to the certainty of death [is] *that it is possible in every moment*,' and not just 'sometime later' (Heidegger 1996, 238, italics Heidegger's). I would not be incapable of resolutely anticipating my death if (and because) I ended up on death row in Texas with a set date of execution, or if the doctors were somehow able to tell me that I had only two months to live. Even in these cases, I might die before the given date, and hence I would still face a constant threat. Heidegger's understanding of authentic anticipation of death does not concern a future that lies in the 'sometime,' but concerns one's ownmost possibility *here and now*; my mortality is not a matter of something that might happen (be objectively

The climactic force of Roy's death is perhaps the feature of the film that most calls for comparison with the film's great predecessor in the fiction of emancipation, Harriet Beecher Stowe's 1851 novel, *Uncle Tom's Cabin, or, Life Among the Lowly*.⁵⁴ Like *Blade Runner*, the novel's central concern is to reveal the humanity of agents consigned to a status less than that of human beings, and to bring out the moral implications of this. And, as in Scott's filmic portrayal of the hunting of runaway slaves, the death of the persecuted slave is the climactic moment of revelation in the book. But there is a crucial difference. Tom's death plays a significant role in the book because of the effect it has on the white son of his former master, George, who is by the time of Tom's death a grown man and master of his father's estate. It was, as George announces to the slaves to whom he grants manumission at the close of the book, 'on [Tom's] grave, my friends, that I resolved, before God, that I would never own another slave, while it was possible to free him' (Stowe 1982, 509).⁵⁵ In the film too, the witness to death exemplifies the proper response to the truth that has been demonstrated—in this case, joining with Rachel and fleeing the city. But here the witness of Roy's death is not a human being who recognizes the humanity of one who was previously dismissed as less than human, as the white George recognizes the spiritual force of the black Tom; instead, it is a fellow Replicant, one who has spent the bulk of the film hunting Replicants. The point here is not primarily to accept the disgraced other, or, as in the encounter with skepticism concerning other minds, to allow oneself to be convinced that the other has a mind and has feelings, but to see something about one's self, and to see oneself as compromised in a way that Stowe's noble George is not.

I wrote above that the Replicants are best understood as inauthentic or *uneigentlich* persons in a Heideggerian sense. On the account that Heidegger gives in *Being and Time*, human beings (*Da-sein*) as such should be understood in this sense. Inauthenticity is our default status, and 'authentic being one's self' is an 'existentiell modification' of this (Heidegger 1996, 122). Heidegger describes this normal, everyday

present) 'someday,' but rather a central part of what and who I *am now*. Plainly, all of this is true of the Replicants as well, some of whom die before their four year life span runs out, and none of whom seems to know his or her exact 'incept date,' least of all his or her actual time of death. The four-year limit to their life span does not change the nature of their mortality, but rather makes it more difficult for them to evade it.

⁵⁴ Written in response to the 1850 Fugitive Slave Act that enabled southern and western slaveholders and their delegates to hunt for runaway slaves throughout the United States, Stowe's novel is probably the most politically significant work of fiction ever written, playing as it did a huge role of the Abolitionist movement that helped trigger the U.S. Civil War.

⁵⁵ He continues, 'So, when you rejoice in your freedom, think that you owe it to that good old soul, and pay it back in kindness to his wife and children. Think of your freedom, every time you see UNCLE TOM'S CABIN; and let it be a memorial to put you all in mind to follow his steps, and be as honest and faithful and Christian as he was.'

inauthenticity in terms that directly recall the Replicants and their ‘borrowed’ memories when he writes, ‘Everyone is the other [*der Andere*], and no one is himself’ (Heidegger 1996, 120 and Heidegger 2001, 128). But this dispersion, or alienation, is itself a state of possibility. Deckard is a miserable man when he thinks that he is a man who hunts and ‘retires’ Replicants. It is only when he comes to understand what this truly entails that he is in a position to truly open himself to Rachel, to truly be himself. (In the context of the question of the authentic, Heidegger cites Pindar’s dictum, ‘become what you are’ [Heidegger 1996, 136].) It is Roy who helps him learn this, practicing what Heidegger terms ‘authentic care.’ In this mode of caring for the other, one does not step in for the other and do his work for him, making him ‘dependent and dominated,’ as in inauthentic care; one ‘does not so much leap in for the other as *leap ahead* of him, not in order to take “care” away from him, but to first give it back to him as such. This concern . . . helps the other to become transparent to himself *in* his care and *free for* it.’ (Heidegger 1996, 114-5).⁵⁶

But if it is Roy who helps Deckard learn who he is, it is Gaff who acknowledges that he has learned this lesson. Gaff’s intimate knowledge of Deckard is most obvious in the origami of the unicorn from Deckard’s dream that Gaff leaves outside Deckard’s door. It is already hinted at much earlier in the film, when Gaff leaves another origami (to which Scott devotes a lengthy close-up) in Leon’s room as he and Deckard leave it after Deckard searches it. This first origami appears to be either a man with a long tail or a three-legged man. Seen as a man with a tail, the image recalls man’s kinship with the chimpanzee and other simians, and ultimately their shared descent from ‘the apes,’ which in turn further emphasizes the importance of the ‘evolution’ of the Replicants and the question of their (evolutionary) relation to humanity. Seen as a three-legged man, the origami evokes the riddle of the Sphinx, ‘What goes on four legs in the morning, on two legs at noon, and on three legs in the evening?’ The answer, which in the most famous account of the riddle is supplied by Oedipus, is, ‘man.’ In a city cast into seemingly permanent night, this suggests that man is now old, and that man’s child—the Replicant—shall soon be called upon to take his place, as in the evolutionary tale. But the second interpretation also suggests something about Deckard—as it should, given the context in which it appears. Seen in terms of the riddle of the Sphinx, the image recalls not just the biography of the human being, but the tale of Oedipus, the brilliant man who, having solved the riddle of the sphinx, still does not know who he himself is, the son of his wife and the killer of his father.

⁵⁶ It is in all likelihood only a happy coincidence that Roy actually *leaps ahead* of Deckard immediately before saving him.

Deckard can only begin to learn who he himself is and whom he has killed when he acknowledges and mourns Roy; and this in turn puts Deckard in a position in which he might be acknowledged by Gaff. This is a crucial step in the film, and it is one that again underlines the difference between the film and more standard conversion/liberation tales like *Uncle Tom's Cabin*. In a story intended to open the reader to the oppressed other, acknowledgment is unidirectional: it is a gift granted to the despised other. Here, the beneficiary of Deckard's acknowledgment is not Roy, but Deckard. Immediately after Roy dies, Gaff appears, announcing, 'You've done a man's job, sir'—praise either rich with irony (given that Deckard did not kill Roy, and that, as we have seen, a man's job in this world is hardly worthy of much esteem) or else a reference not to blade running, but to mourning. Gaff understands without being told that Deckard is through serving as a Blade Runner, and, *after* getting confirmation of this, throws Deckard his gun anyway. The origami of the unicorn that he leaves for Deckard shows that Gaff knows Deckard to be a Replicant; and he knows full well that Rachel is too, and that Bryant has insisted that Deckard 'retire' her as well. But Gaff lets them both go. This lends a deep significance to the fact that it is only in this final scene, after Deckard has witnessed Roy's death, that Gaff speaks to Deckard in language - English - that Deckard can understand. In a film that is easily seen as putting all of its weight on the romance between Deckard and Rachel this is, I think, a sign of a wider and deeper community, albeit one that, like that shared by Deckard and Rachel alone, rests upon an acknowledgment of the mortal other that Deckard, and we, resist for so long.

Blade Runner is easily seen as a thought experiment concerning artificial life and the possibility of such life achieving the status of the human. Understood in this way, the film has obvious problems. With its beautiful, lush, romantic music, the film completely shies away from the most disturbing implication of the possibility of replicating human life, that of manufacturing more than one 'copy' of the same person. This possibility is hardly something of which Scott could have been unaware, given the major part it plays in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* In Dick's novel, Rachel and Pris are duplicates, and it is clear that there may be many more just like them. In the film, however, each Replicant is wholly distinct in terms of physical features as well as character. One might conclude that Scott has taken the easy way out, and invited his audience to identify with Replicants without showing them as they really are, or could be. But this misses the point, as the film, in the end, is not about Replicants at all: it's about the viewer. The point is not to ask whether you will or will not embrace a Replicant slave as a being like yourself, but to ask what sort of being you are; not to ask whether Replicants can feel empathy, but whether you do; not to ask whether your memories are your own, but whether your memories in the end are what make you what you are; not to ask what death

could mean for a robot, but what it means to you; and, finally, not to ask whether you know the beings around you to be human, but to observe what such acknowledgment might entail and demand.⁵⁷

⁵⁷ I am grateful to Stuart Warner for initially inviting me to speak on *Blade Runner* at the Montesquieu Forum at Roosevelt University in Chicago. His responses and those of the other members of the audience were very helpful to me, as were the detailed comments of two anonymous reviewers for *Film-Philosophy*. I would also like to thank Tom Carlson for stimulating me to think more about the ‘opening to the other’ in Heidegger’s *Being and Time*, and Dieter Thomä for helpful conversations regarding Heidegger’s understanding of *Vorlaufen zum Tode*.

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